

SUCCESSFUL INTERCEPTION

A Messerschmitt Bf 110 is shot down by a Hurricane over southern England. The heavy German twin-engined fighter was no match for RAF Spitfires or Hurricanes in a dogfight.

behind his back, he could barely move. He sat with his right hand on the control stick, his left on the throttle, and his two feet on the rudder bar. His right thumb rested on the firing button for his guns, which was on top of the control column. The guns were as immobile as the pilot, and in combat the pilot aimed the plane at the target. He had enough ammunition to fire for about 13 seconds on each sortie.

The Luftwaffe fighter-escort pilots, in their Messerschmitt Bf 109s or 110s, liked to function as marauding hunters with their bomber force as bait. Lurking at high altitude in the loose “finger-four” formation – two pairs, each consisting of a lead pilot and his wingman – they would dive down to “bounce” the RAF fighters advancing in threes in tight V formations, especially picking off the vulnerable aircraft at the back of the V. This kind of combat could be over in seconds. The victim of a Messerschmitt diving out of the sun would probably never see the aircraft that shot him down. Exploiting the accumulated speed of the dive, the Messerschmitts could make their escapes before any response was possible.

If the RAF fighters could engage the Messerschmitts in a dogfight they stood a much better chance. On the whole, the Spitfires and even the slower Hurricanes could outmaneuver the Bf 109s, and they were certainly more agile than the Bf 110s. In combat, where the key maneuver was a tight turn to get on the enemy's tail, a good RAF pilot would probably come out on top.

Dowding's orders were that the fighters should concentrate on shooting down bombers. A division of labor developed, with the Spitfires holding off the Luftwaffe fighter cover while the Hurricanes went for the fleets of Heinkels, Junkers, and Dorniers. Bombers were not easy targets. The He 111s – the most numerous Luftwaffe bomber – were by this time partly armored, and the Ju 88s were sturdy and fast. Their skillful gunners downed substantial numbers of RAF fighters. The most effective way of attacking a bomber formation was to fly straight at it from the front, an especially unnerving experience for bomber crews clustered in the nose of their aircraft behind plexiglass. However, few fighter pilots had the nerve to risk collision, and most attacked bombers from behind or, occasionally, the flank. It was relatively easy to score hits on a bomber, but bringing one down was more difficult. Many made it back to their airfields riddled with bullet

holes, often carrying one or two seriously injured or dead crew members.

The Messerschmitts were not really suited to the role of bomber escort. The Bf 109 had inadequate range, allowing the briefest spell in the combat zone. The Bf 110 had the required range, but was not a good enough dogfighter. When mounting bomber losses forced the Messerschmitts to take their escort duties more seriously, making some fly in close support, instead of 10,000ft (3km) above, this was extremely unpopular with Messerschmitt pilots. RAF fighter pilots had their own discontents. Some chafed at the discipline imposed by ground controllers, fuming when their hunting instincts were frustrated in the interest of some wider tactical scheme.

In the hot seat

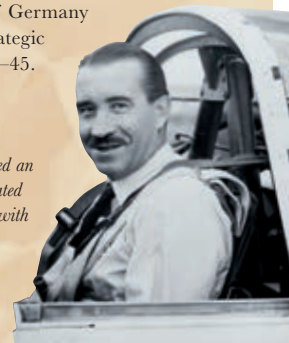
Nevertheless, fighter pilots and their skills were ultimately the key factor determining victory or defeat. Thanks to the sterling efforts of British aircraft factories, there was never a serious chance

ADOLF GALLAND

LUFTWAFFE ACE Adolf Galland (1912–96) first saw action in Spain during the civil war, where he established a reputation as an expert in ground-support operations. Desperate to transfer to a fighter squadron early in World War II, he got a doctor's certificate to say he was not fit to fly in an open-cockpit, ground-support aircraft. Galland fought in the Battle of Britain as commander of fighter group JG26. He was an instantly recognizable character, with his slicked-back hair, thick mustache, and ever-present cigar (he had an ashtray installed in his Messerschmitt cockpit). Galland saw himself as a free-ranging hunter and was obsessively involved in the quest to be “top gun,” comparing his running score every day with that of his great rival, Werner Mölders. Devoted to the romantic view of the fighter pilot as an individual warrior, he was derisive of innovations such as in-cockpit radio. Galland later commanded the fighter defense of Germany against Allied strategic bombing in 1943–45.

JOVIAL ACE

Adolf Galland sported an easy smile and decorated one of his Bf 109s with an image of Mickey Mouse. But behind the jovial persona lay a cool hunter obsessed with kills.



system was also efficient and robust, with most communications depending on standard telephone lines that were impossible to jam and easy to repair.

The call to scramble

The radar-based early-warning system relieved Fighter Command of the need to mount continuous combat air patrols, for which it simply did not have the resources. Nevertheless, response times were very tight. Fighter pilots always ran to their aircraft when the call to “scramble” came through, because every second meant a chance to gain more height before encountering the enemy. It typically took five minutes for a squadron to get airborne, which was rarely quick enough to avoid beginning the fight at an altitude disadvantage.

Once airborne, the pilot in a Spitfire or Hurricane – or for that matter in a Messerschmitt Bf 109 – was effectively welded to his machine. Strapped tightly into the small metal cockpit, with its plexiglass hood, a bulletproof windshield in front of him, and, in most cases, an armor plate

